Practical Compassion for Destitute Children

A Registered Charity no. 1076588

Website: www.pcdcuk.com

Early Spring Newsletter 2026

Dear Friends,

Most people I meet are feeling wearied by this long, grey winter. I cannot remember a new year bringing so many days of rain, wind and cold. And here in the North East we have fared better than many other parts of the country. Meanwhile we turn on the television news, or reach for a newspaper, and are made instantly and vividly aware of what life is like in the Middle East, or Ukraine, or many other parts of the world.

At least we can do something!

I feel on the one hand that we know we are doing something through the work of PCDC, though it sometimes feels like a drop in the ocean. And together we are making a difference to one young life after another. It was so gratifying to see our contributions increasing rather than decreasing in 2025. Thank you so much for that!

On the other hand, seeing how life has become more precarious than ever for some of our Palestinian families leaves me longing for a sort of springtime, a time of new hope and stability for the families and for the schools. When parents have been unable to get to work for months, their income simply vanishes. When tourists and pilgrims have been unable to visit Palestine, the shops and cafes they would have been patronising simply stay shut.

Palestine on the alert

While we wait anxiously to see whether the fragile cease-fire will hold in Gaza and the long process of rebuilding will begin, the situation in Palestine has in some ways grown more tense. We continue to hear about the advance of the settlers, and reports about the seizing and demolition of homes, such as happened to our valued colleague Mahmoud and his family in 2024.

Even as we are putting this Newsletter together, the situation is changing alarmingly from day to day. Malcolm and I have put together some reports in a separate section of this Newsletter. I hope you will find this helpful.

Our 30th birthday

PCDC came to life during 1996. There was not an official launch, just a gradual development during that year of the work which has been going on ever since. We are going to celebrate that landmark sometime next spring/early summer with a Party to which you will be invited! We hope the date for the party can be agreed in the next week or two. At present, we are considering Saturday afternoons in June.

We have already announced that another way we shall observe our 30th birthday will be by compiling and publishing a commemorative booklet, including a short history of PCDC, and reflections on what has been happening down the years from those in the UK and in Palestine. If you have stories,

memories or impressions I shall be delighted to receive them in the next few weeks. We are not looking for long essays, just anecdotes and memories.

The booklet will be printed and distributed quite separately from our main funds, which will continue to be dedicated 100% for the assistance of destitute children in Palestine.

I hope that this Newsletter will give you hope and encouragement that the work of PCDC is keeping going amidst all the challenges.

Please share this Newsletter with your friends, your church and with anyone who might like to support us. We give thanks that God continues to bless our work and the children who are enabled through it to learn and grow.

With my love and prayers,

Richard Hill

Canon Richard Hill became Chair of PCDC in 2023. You can contact him on 07597 933 367 or by email at collis.rick@gmail.com

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Malcolm writes about the meaning of 'destitution' in our name

Dear Friends,

PCDC is a servant charity, not a political organization. We know that children everywhere deserve to grow up in safety, dignity, and freedom. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) sets out the fundamental rights that all children should enjoy, regardless of nationality, ethnicity, or circumstance. These standards are recognised worldwide, yet their observance varies between countries. While many nations strive to uphold the UNCRC, children in certain areas, including Israel and the occupied Palestinian territories, continue to face severe violations of their rights. The ongoing conflict and occupation have led to situations where basic protections are not guaranteed, causing long-term harm and distress to children living in these regions.

Here is a list of UN-recognised Children's Rights

1. The right to life, survival, and development. As we have seen, many children in Palestine have lost their lives in the last few years of conflict. In the area where PCDC works, this has not affected so many children, but many children who we know have lost their freedom to travel about, even in their own city, and have been denied all kinds of possibility of full development of their skills and needs.

2. The right to safety from harm and abuse. Everyone has the right to be protected from violence, abuse, and neglect, but this right has often been ignored. Violence is widespread; even older teenagers can feel unsafe walking outside. Children we know have been threatened by soldiers who broke into their home at night and threatened them with firearms. There have been instances where young children suffered gunshot wounds to their stomachs.

3. The right to education. This is a basic necessity for every child born. In Palestine the government schools cost less to attend but there are many problems. Huge classes (average 75 children per class) mean that children with special needs cannot be attended to. Teachers are government employees, several months behind in

receiving their salary, which for the past three years has been paid only at 50% per month. This means schools are often on strike and therefore closed. Christian and other private schools offer small classes (average 15 per class) with maximum attention to the needs of each child. Exam results are generally much better, and the schools run well and are clean. Government schools that we know lack doors on the classrooms, and the toilets do not work. PCDC works in17 different schools and the education of children is our priority. We cover school fees for 170 children, in part or completely, according to each child's needs. Our annual budget for this is around £120,000.

4. The right to health and healthcare. Every child has a right to healthcare. In Palestine there has been much improvement, and the doctors and hospitals are doing the best they can. But they are often underequipped, and the doctors lack up-to-date training. PCDC will try to help any child who is unable to pay for medical help. Many times, there are complications that only the Israeli hospitals can help. We have found all Israeli hospitals helpful and kind and offer Palestinian children the very best of modern care. But at a high cost, sometimes running to five figures. PCDC has often found it easier to get permits to take children into Israel for good treatment, where the parents struggle to get the paperwork. Another problem is water. Every child has the right to good clean water. In Palestine, people often collect rainwater to drink and wash with. Farmers who have underground water sources are not allowed to use them. Israeli law means that all water belongs to the Israelis, so farmers must pay high prices to buy back their own water. Between Hebron and Bethlehem, two large cities 17 miles apart, there is one valve which only the Israelis control, by which the entire city of Hebron can be cut off from their water supply. We have known this situation to last for several days, affecting the rights of every child.

5. The right to express opinions and be heard. The difficulty here is that children can be locked up in juvenile Israeli prisons without trial and without access to lawyers. We know children who have been locked away for 2 or 3 years for very minor offences. Often the parents are denied access to these prisons which are far away from Palestine. Permits for parental visits are often denied and no reasons given. We also know from official Israeli sources that children can be held without trial for unlimited periods of time. They are offered payment on release if they betray other Palestinians. Turning down this offer can extend their stay in prison.

6. The right to play and leisure. Access to play, leisure, and a safe family environment is frequently disrupted by ongoing conflict. In Bethlehem there is only one playground for children, hard beside the "security wall", which is covered by a laser gun, threatening children who raise their hands while playing. PCDC helped to repair unsafe equipment in this playground some years ago. So far as we know, the gun has never fired. But it still points to children playing in this playground.

7. The right to family life and parental care. Every child should have the ability to live with parents or other family members. There are too many children wandering in the streets. One child we know (aged 13) asked the police for permission to commit a crime so that he could spend a night in a cell, rather than in the street where he usually slept. PCDC was able to move him into a residential school.

Rights Violated in Palestine

Children in Palestine are suffering from the denial of several of these rights. Many have limited access to education due to sudden school closures and roads to schools being closed off by the Israeli Army. The right to health is often compromised by restrictions on medical supplies and movement. Medication which is available in Jerusalem is not available in Bethlehem, 5 miles away. All roads to Jerusalem are closed to Palestinians, so they can't buy these medicines in Jerusalem. Exposure to violence, detention, and psychological trauma are widespread, violating their rights to protection and development. Access to play, leisure, and a safe family environment is frequently disrupted by ongoing conflict and displacement. Palestinian homes are sometimes destroyed by IDF bulldozers with only a few minutes' notice. PCDC is caring for 12 children who have lost their homes without compensation. They are simply told to go and live somewhere else.

The Role of Practical Compassion for Destitute Children (PCDC)

PCDC is dedicated to defending and promoting the rights of children in Palestine. We work to support affected families, and our efforts focus especially on safeguarding children from violence, ensuring access to education and healthcare, and upholding the right to family life. By raising awareness, PCDC strives to ensure that children receive the protections they are entitled to under international law.

Conclusion: The Importance of Upholding Children's Rights

Protecting children's rights is a universal responsibility. The ongoing challenges faced by children in Palestine highlight the urgent need for global solidarity and action. By supporting organisations like PCDC, we can help children, regardless of where they live, to enjoy the rights and dignity they deserve. This is why we define Destitution as the denial to children of their rights.

Malcolm Jones

Jasmine's Story

Sometimes God leads us in funny ways. When we are working in Bethlehem, we tend to travel in local taxis. These are not private taxis, but run along a route like buses do, and they are very quick and cheap, and will stop anywhere you ask them to. They are called service taxis and can take up to 12 passengers. They are a good way of getting about. On one trip we heard people talking in the town and the taxis about this young woman who had developed a kind of a cist which needed treating.

She was expecting her first son. She and her husband already had several daughters. They were looking forward to the little boy. The cist was a very small procedure. She went into the local hospital. They gave her an injection. Sadly, they gave her the wrong one. Within a few hours, she was dead. As I often say, Palestinian hospitals do the best they can; but they are under-funded, and the doctors are not always up to date in their treatment methods. Mistakes happen, and there is never any compensation. The little boy she was bearing also died. The family was broken in despair.

We felt God was calling us to go and minister to that family, if there was any way we could lighten the terrible burden that had come to them so suddenly. People soon directed us to the house, and I was one of the two members of PCDC who went to call on them. The father was beside himself in grief, and all the girls were stunned in unbelief at what had happened to their mother. It isn't easy to minister in these circumstances, but it was made easier for us when the youngest girl, who was 5 years old, asked us when her Mummy would be coming back? Again, no easy answer. But we often carry trauma bears with us, and we had one, which we offered to Jasmine (not her real name) as a comfort. The girls began to speak a bit, and we learnt that one of the sisters was about to be confirmed in the Catholic Church the very next day. Luckily, we knew the Catholic priest, and we went to see him. He had worked alongside PCDC before, and we had always got on very well together.

There would be the problem of school fees. Father was unemployed, soon to start a modest job at an Israeli supermarket. It wouldn't cover the girls' school fees. We made a plan: PCDC would pay half the school fees and Father John would help us to pay the other half. The girls' father received only a fraction of his rightful wage, as Palestinians working in Israeli shops are paid much less. Meanwhile, the sister to be confirmed next day wanted to tell us about the confirmation, because she had been asked to do a Bible reading in the church, and she had been practising it, and wanted us to hear her. She read it to us, and we listened, pretending we understood every word! She read it slowly and clearly and with good expression and we encouraged her and promised we would be there to pray for her, and to stand in for her father, who could not bear to go back to the church where so recently he had attended his wife's funeral service. In the event, she read perfectly and we were happy to be there, representing her parents.

Time went by. Each year the fees bill came to us from the school for each of the girls. There was always the discount, which the priest found for them. We paid the balance. The girls each worked hard. One by one, they passed all their exams. Jasmine grew in her own way and is now one of the most popular girls in the school. Two of the girls have got their degree at the university (PCDC pay the full fee now) and one is married. Only Jasmine is left at school, and PCDC is still keeping our promise to her and the sisters who are still at university. We are glad to watch this family overcome their grief. Father is currently without any work. Sometimes, when we help families, it is for a long haul, but worth it, thanks to all our supporters. We are so grateful to you for making this ministry possible over many years.

Malcolm Jones

The Revd Malcolm Jones is a founding trustee of PCDC. You are welcome to be in touch with him at malcolmjonespcdc@hotmail.com or by phone: 07743 546 180

What on earth are we to make of the present situation in the Middle East?

Readers of our Newsletter will be wondering how the recent and sudden escalation of violence throughout the Middle East is affecting our children and the work of PCDC.

The first thing to say is that for the present generation of Palestinian children this is their first experience of full-on war. The Intifada (1999-2003) was the last sustained period of war.

Children now are experiencing the deafening and terrifying sound of drones and ballistic missiles either flying over or crashing into buildings. Every school is closed at present; roads are closed and many new checkpoints have been set up. It is dangerous to be out of doors, so everyone is confined to their houses. There are no air-raid shelters in Palestine; the only place of refuge (if you have one) is the basement of your house.

One friend has written to us:

> *'All the roads to and from Bethlehem have been closed. The sirens around us and sounding constantly. We do not know what is happening. We are only trying to reassure our children, who are innocent and have never seen a truly beautiful day.'*

And from another:

> *'I am very upset! Who is benefitting from this war? Is the whole world unable to say "Enough!" to the occupation? Martyrs, prisoners, home demolitions, external wars, road closures and so one .. We are exhausted from this situation.'*

And from the president of one of our schools:

> '*While the events of the last three years have been disruptive to our school, the violence that has erupted over the last few days is right in front of us day and night – threatening the welfare, and potentially the lives, of our children, their families and the school staff.*
>
> *Now as warning sirens blare and rockets rain overhead, citizens of the West Bank are physically and emotionally stressed. They don't know when or where the missiles could hit, and the only shelter they have is the basement of their homes (the "Iron Dome" that protects Israel does not extend into Palestine). Our students, who continually live with the trauma caused by the last three years of conflict, now have a war that has been brought to their doorsteps as they hear warning sirens and the sound of rocket explosions.'*

Hopefully this will inform our prayers and understanding of the present situation which is changing from day to day.

Malcolm and Richard

The Last Word ...

If you have a question about our activities and policies in PCDC, please don't hesitate to ask. We will be happy to provide answers and explanations either personally or in future Newsletters.

Similarly, please be in touch if you have suggestions about how our work could be developed.

To make a donation to PCDC by bank transfer:

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